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Marcin Tereszewski

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Disneyland and Its Discontents: J.G. Ballard and the Commodification of Dissent

Marcin Tereszewski

Department of English Philology, University of Wrocław, Wrocław, Poland

ABSTRACT
This article reads J.G. Ballard's *Cocaine Nights* alongside Disneyland as parallel case studies in the absorption of utopian desire into the architectures of late capitalism. It examines the novel as a critical intervention into the cultural logic of late capitalism, focusing on its representation of leisure societies as hyperreal utopias sustained by commodified transgression. It will be argued that Estrella de Mar, the novel's luxury resort on Spain's Costa del Sol, mirrors Disneyland's meticulous spatial design and thematic simulation, yet inverts its logic: where Disneyland suppresses conflict to preserve the fantasy of harmony, Estrella deliberately engineers deviance to sustain social cohesion. Drawing on Fredric Jameson, Jean Baudrillard, and David Harvey, the paper situates Ballard's narrative within broader debates on the waning of affect and the domestication of dissent. By reading Ballard's fictional resort alongside Disneyland's cheerful authoritarianism, the article argues that utopian desire in the neoliberal era is not extinguished but perverted. Under such conditions, rebellion is aestheticized, dissent becomes a lifestyle accessory, and the utopian imagination is redirected into forms that reinforce the very systems it once sought to resist.

Introduction

In the summer of 1955, Walt Disney opened the gates to what he called "the happiest place on Earth." Sixty years later, street artist Banksy countered with *Dismaland*, his dystopian art installation described as a "sinister twist on Disneyland," a recognition that Disney's utopian vision had degenerated into something more disconcerting. Between these two moments lies a fundamental transformation in how utopian desire functions. What began as a utopian promise of technological progress and social harmony has evolved into a sophisticated system for managing dissent and neutralizing alternatives.

This transformation reflects a broader crisis in utopian imagination. As Fredric Jameson and Mark Fisher have argued, capitalism, apart from governing our economic life, also constrains our very capacity to think beyond it. The oft-quoted maxim "it's easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism"[1] succinctly captures this foreclosure of alternatives, a condition that found political expression in Margaret Thatcher's declaration that "there is no alternative." Under such conditions, utopian aspiration does not disappear; instead, it becomes absorbed into the very system it once sought to transcend.

Disneyland serves as the paradigmatic example of this absorption. More than simply a theme park, it functions as a spatial and ideological metaphor for how late capitalism transforms utopian desire into consumer spectacle. Through meticulous behavioral engineering disguised as entertainment, Disneyland pioneered techniques of "soft control" that have since become

CONTACT Marcin Tereszewski marcin.tereszewski@uwr.edu.pl Department of English Philology, University of Wrocław, ul. Kuźnicza 22, Wrocław 50-138, Poland
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fundamental to contemporary urban planning, corporate architecture, and social management. Yet Disneyland represents only one possible configuration of commodified utopia. J. G. Ballard's 1996 novel *Cocaine Nights* imagines an alternative model, one where transgression itself becomes the mechanism of social cohesion. Set in the luxury resort community of Estrella de Mar on Spain's Costa del Sol, the novel explores what happens when a post-industrial society achieves its utopian dream of liberation from work, only to discover that comfort without conflict breeds existential emptiness.

This article examines how *Cocaine Nights* dramatizes the crisis of utopian imagination under late capitalism by staging a confrontation between two models of commodified utopia: Disneyland's suppression of conflict and Ballard's engineering of it. *Cocaine Nights* offers a particularly rich site for this inquiry because it explicitly thematizes the engineering of community through transgression, making visible mechanisms that typically operate beneath consciousness. Read together, these two "utopian" spaces reveal similar traits: antiseptic cleanliness, a-historicity, and affective flatness. Moreover, both spaces reveal how late capitalism has learned to absorb and redirect utopian energy rather than simply suppress it. Where earlier forms of social control operated through prohibition and punishment, contemporary capitalism operates through what we might call "curated transgression," which amounts to the systematic production of manageable forms of deviance, thereby inoculating the governing system against genuine alternatives.

Disneyland and the Absorption of Utopian Desire

Disneyland and its sister parks, more than any other architectural structure, have come to exemplify how utopia and capitalism merge in late modernity. Film and literature have often called on Disneyland as a cultural shorthand to interrogate the threat of oppressive utopian communities, presenting them as if they were wolves in sheep's clothing. The oppression is oftentimes overlooked or simply accepted as a price to pay for the utopian benefits. In speculative fiction especially, Disneyland has become a potent symbol of the convergence of authoritative control and consumer desire. Such works as Cory Doctrow's novel *Down and Out in the Magic Kingdom* (2003), Paul McAuley's *Fairyland* (1995), Michael Crichton's film *Westworld* (1973), and Brad Bird's movie *Tomorrowland* (2015) depict theme park-like spaces that blur the line between entertainment and social engineering by revealing how the former works in the service of the latter. Banksy's already mentioned dystopian *Dismaland* further reinforces the park's enduring role as a metaphor for cheerful oppression under late capitalism.

Disneyland epitomizes a meticulously crafted fusion of enchantment and engineering, the result of which is a kind of cheerful oppression reminiscent of Huxley's *Brave New World*. As M. Keith Booker argues, this duality "mirrors the nature of the utopian project itself, which takes its inspiration from both fantasy and technology" (Booker 1). In this sense, the theme park can be seen as a space in which preconceived social order is achieved through technological design and behavioral management. Yet beneath the seemingly benign veneer of artificial paradise lies a subtle but persistent sense of menace. The ideal of perfect order is inseparable from the threat of repression – a tension articulated by David Harvey, who notes that: "Perhaps Utopia can never be realized without destroying itself" (107). Disneyland, seen as a microcosm of this tension, reveals the ambivalence at the heart of utopianism. On the one hand, it is a triumph of social engineering, managing the massive influx of visitors with seamless efficiency. Every aspect of the visitor experience – from crowd flow to emotional pacing – is scripted, beginning with the distribution of a map that subtly dictates the movement of tourists through the park. Attractions are sequenced to produce an optimized experience, one that prioritizes pleasure, immersion, and safety. The park manages to cultivate a seamless atmosphere in which waiting becomes part of the spectacle. This level of behavioral design constitutes what Michel Foucault might call a "soft disciplinary apparatus" – a system of control not through coercion, but through spatial arrangement, affective modulation, and cultural scripting. At the same time, this carefully choreographed orderliness evokes a kind of soft authoritarianism, where control is exerted not

through force but through the subtleties of spatial design and cultural scripting. The docility with which visitors conform to these conventions is perhaps the most unsettling aspect of the theme park experience. As Booker observes,

> . . . the most sinister aspect of the park is the way its many millions of visitors succumb so meekly to being herded about the park like cattle (or inmates), buying what they are supposed to buy, seeing what they are supposed to see, and spending countless hours standing in queues waiting for the privilege of doing so. Disneyworld is both the idealization of the American dream and the ideal carceral society of consumer capitalism. (3)

The organization of social movement and behavior appears a bit too calculated and too efficient, the severance from the outside reality a bit too complete. Booker's allusion to incarceration reflects the idea that the park's apparent harmony is sustained by pervasive surveillance. Indeed, Disneyland serves as one of the earliest and most successful examples of large-scale CCTV surveillance, a model that would later be replicated extensively in urban planning and public spaces. While large-scale, pervasive surveillance brings about ominous associations with repressive police states, the Disneyland's invisible watchfulness is not experienced as intrusive but as part of the park's benign omnipresence. Disneyland becomes a microcosm of a disciplinary society in which social engineering is camouflaged as consumerism and entertainment, allowing people to be blissfully unaware of the extent to which they are being controlled.

This line of reasoning is taken up by David Harvey, who in *Spaces of Hope* draws on Jean-François Marin's concept of degenerate utopias to describe spaces that reinforce rather than challenge the ideological structures of capitalist society. These spaces offer not genuine alternative beyond commodified fantasy that obscure rather than interrogate the conditions of their own existence; they "merely perpetuates the fetish of commodity culture and technological wizardry in a pure, sanitized, and a-historical form" (Harvey 107). The "utopia" of Disneyland thus reveals itself to be deeply dystopian in its effects. By producing pleasure through control, and nostalgia through erasure, the park embodies the very contradictions at the heart of late capitalist society. As Harvey puts it bluntly: "we are surrounded by a host of degenerate utopias of which Disneyland is but the most spectacular example" (198). It manages to make control feel like freedom, consumption feel like transcendence, and repetition feel like novelty.

Cocaine Nights and the pathology of transgression

As D. Harlan Wilson has observed, the novel's title is rather misleading: the titular drug scarcely makes an appearance. Rather, "It's more of a signifier for breaking the law and tapping jouissance from the cask of illicit behavior" (Wilson 153). The title can be taken to simply evoke the image of hedonistic escape and endless indulgence; it can also gesture gestures toward an ironic utopianism, recalling the medieval myth of Cockaigne (pronounced identically) – a land of abundance and hedonism, unfettered by conflict and morality.

> Out to sea, far west of Spain
> Lies the land men call Cokaygne
> No land that under heaven is,
> For wealth and goodness comes near this;
> . . .
> In Cogaygne we drink and eat
> Freely without care and sweat,
> The food is choice and clear the wine,
> At fourses and at supper time,
> I say again, and I dare swear,
> No land is like it anywhere,
> Under heaven no land like this
> Of such joy and endless bliss (The Utopia Reader, 71–72)

This medieval utopian fantasy of wish-fulfillment is analogous to Ballard's resort communities in several ways. They both lean toward corporal rather than spiritual satisfaction, where reveling in carnal pleasures and satiating worldly appetites trumps spiritual needs and intellectual development. It is precisely this morally transgressive aspect of Cockaigne that sets it apart from religious representations of heaven. A more critical – or satirical – depiction of Cockaigne was given form by Pieter Bruegel the Elder in Het Luilekkerland (The Land of Cockaigne, c. 1567). Here, Cockaigne is not an idyllic paradise but rather a grotesque critique of excess, laziness, and the illusion of effortless abundance.

Cocaine Nights presents a modern reimagining of Cockaigne, though Ballard's portrayal is laced with critical irony not altogether different from that found in Bruegel's satirical depiction. Set in Estrella de Mar, a luxury resort community on Spain's Costa del Sol, the novel explores the dark undercurrents of a society that appears to epitomize the dream of a post-work society. Described as a place where "a billion balconies facing the sun," Estrella de Mar conjures an image of untroubled existence, a world where everyone can devote themselves to the pursuit of leisure. As such, Estrella de Mar serves as a culmination of late capitalist fantasies, the natural endpoint of a post-industrial society in which the affluent have been liberated from work and historical burden. As such, the community stands as a dystopian culmination of late capitalist utopianism: a society where affluence has liberated its citizens from the necessity of work but also from the texture of lived reality.

> Our governments are preparing for a future without work [. . .]. Leisure societies lie ahead of us, like those you see on this coast. People will still work – or, rather, some people will work, but only for a decade of their lives. They will retire in their late thirties, with fifty years of idleness in front of them. (Ballard 180)

This imagined, ostensibly desirable, future becomes, in Ballard's hands, a tableau of existential inertia. Estrella de Mar is not a utopia in the classical sense, where freedom and human potential flourish, but a post-industrial cul-de-sac in which leisure degenerates into pathology.

Ballard's late fiction – *Super-Cannes* (2000), *Cocaine Nights* (1996), *Millennium People* (2003), and *Kingdom Come* (2006) – is firmly rooted in the post-industrial landscapes of late capitalism: corporate parks, shopping malls, and gated communities, environments that blend utopianism and capitalism, offering a promise of safety and comfort while concealing the coercive mechanisms that underpin the seemingly utopian social structure.

One common criticism of Ballard's late fiction highlights how similar these novels are, as if Ballard obsessively returned to the same themes in pursuit of getting them right. What follows is a quick survey to contextualize *Cocaine Nights*. In *Super-Cannes*, Eden-Olympia, a corporate enclave on the French Riviera, offers its privileged residents every comfort and security, but this utopian façade is sustained by organized criminality, psychological manipulation, and a carefully curated system of controlled transgression. Ballard presents a vision of the bourgeois unconscious in revolt against its own ennui, where violence becomes a therapeutic outlet. Similarly, *Millennium People* chronicles a middle-class uprising in London's Chelsea Marina, where disaffected professionals rebel not against poverty or injustice but against the banality of bourgeois life. Ballard satirizes a society in which political energy is redirected into lifestyle choices, brand affinities, and impotent gestures of defiance. These themes also recur in his short stories, which have come to be regarded as a kind of testing ground for ideas later developed in his novels. In "The Largest Theme Park in the World" (1989), Ballard imagines a future where people live in giant theme-park suburbs designed to entertain and pacify them, while in "Having a Wonderful Time" (1988), a young couple finds themselves stranded in a holiday resort from which they can never return. So, indeed, the case could be made that he centers around a set assortment of themes, yet this consistency reveals itself as deliberate artistic strategy rather than imaginative exhaustion. Ballard's recurring preoccupations operate like variations on a musical theme, each iteration deepening our understanding of how contemporary society manufactures its own psychopathologies.

The protagonist of *Cocaine Nights*, Charles Prentice, enters the seemingly ideal world of Estrela de Mar, where – in typical utopian fashion – he is gradually initiated into the ways of the community; as

an outsider, he is introduced to various people and to the social rules governing this enclave. His visit is prompted by the arrest of his brother, Frank, who had confessed to murder and arson and is currently incarcerated. Incredulous of the confession, Charles is convinced that there must be another explanation and sets out to prove his brother's innocence in what appears to be a conventional detective-style investigation. While *Cocaine Nights* initially appears to conform to the conventions of detective fiction, Ballard quickly subverts the genre. The mystery of who committed the crime is resolved early on, leaving in its place a deeper and more unsettling inquiry: why did the crime occur, and why is the community so disturbingly at ease with it? In fact, *Cocaine Nights* subverts the detective fiction genre entirely; Charles's investigation never restores order, never reaffirms the law, and never reestablishes the authority of reason or morality. Instead, it exposes a community in which deviance is not a threat to social cohesion but its very precondition. What appears to be a peaceful, affluent, and culturally vibrant community is in fact sustained by carefully orchestrated deviance, an economy of crime and transgression that reanimates a population otherwise numbed by affluence and routine.

This underground crime wave of petty crime, arson, and even murder is orchestrated by Bobby Crawford, a popular tennis coach at the resort and *de facto* social engineer of Estrella de Mar, who serves as the spokesman for the necessity of crime as an antidote to the waning of affect. Charles befriends Bobby, who gradually seduces him into his perverted ideology of disorder. Crawford's campaign of theft, vandalism, and most notably the arson of the well-to-do Hollinger mansion, for which Frank has been imprisoned, can be read as a twisted attempt at social engineering, intended to shock the community out of its lethargy.

> Only one thing is left which can rouse people, threaten them directly and force them to act together [. . .]. Crime, and transgressive behavior – by which I mean all activities that aren't necessarily illegal, but provoke us and tap our need for strong emotion, quicken the nervous system and jump the synapses deadened by leisure and inaction. (Ballard 180)

In his view, crime is not a breakdown of social order but an engineered necessity, a stimulant able to generate excitement and engagement in an otherwise apathetic society and Frank is but one of the fallen heroes who's have sacrificed themselves for the greater cause. This "structure of sacrifice," as described by Philip Tew, stems from Ballard's own "sense of trauma" (109), a sacrificial violence that is shared by postmillennial novels Violence, therefore, becomes utopian in function, if not in form – a paradox that Ballard explores with his patented clinical detachment, presenting how a whole community succumbs to this paradox. While the traditional idea of utopia appears obsolete in post-capitalist society, utopianism understood as an impulse endures, albeit in distorted ways. *Cocaine Nights* thus offers a vision of a society where transgression is built into the system or, in other words, is cannibalized by late capitalism, in which utopian aspiration survives only as pathology.

The Dialectic of Estrella de Mar and Residencia Costasol

Although the function of violence and criminality are important themes in the novel, Ballard's critique also takes the form of spatial and architectural considerations. The environment itself tells a story underpinned by depthlessness, artificiality, and simulation. As Florian Cord observes, the Spanish coast in *Cocaine Nights* becomes "a powerful symbolic of global capitalism and its totalizing forces" (141). Estrella de Mar is not merely a backdrop but a blueprint utopia,[2] sharing with Disneyland key features identified by theorists like Jameson and Baudrillard: a-historicity, depthlessness, and hyper-reality. Disneyland is designed to feel authentic while being entirely artificial; it presents itself as a fantasy world while reinforcing the logic of consumer capitalism. Estrella de Mar operates on similar principles.

At one point in the novel Charles and Bobby Crawford make their way to the nearby gated community of Residencia Costasol. Ballard's portrayal of Residencia Costasol alongside Estrella de Mar creates a comparative framework for understanding how late capitalist utopias can evolve – or devolve – over time. These communities represent two different responses to the same fundamental

condition: the achievement of post-industrial leisure society and its attendant existential crisis. Where Estrella de Mar attempts to solve this crisis through engineered transgression, Costasol represents the more common outcome: complete capitulation to entropy, a community that has fully accepted its own living death.

The temporal distinction Charles observes – "Estrella de Mar was built in the 1970s – open access, street festivals, tourists welcome. The Residentia Costasol is pure 1990s. Security rules. Everything is designed around an obsession with crime" (Ballard 212) – coincides with a broader historical trajectory of neoliberalism. The 1970s community retains vestigial elements of social democratic ideals: public space, cultural events, and openness to outsiders. The 1990s community, by contrast, embodies neoliberal paranoia as evidenced by the privatization of public space, the securitization of daily life, and the treatment of all external contact as potential threat. Costasol's built environment reveals the spatial logic of late capitalist retreat from public life. The community's design, as described by Crawford, has "security guards, tele-surveillance, no entrance except through the main gates, the whole complex closed to outsiders" (Ballard 210), creating in effect what Mike Davis called a "fortress architecture," where defensive measures become the organizing principle of social space. This is architecture designed not for dwelling but for human withdrawal, where every design decision prioritizes security over sociability, isolation over interaction. Whereas Estrella cultivates an image of open, sun-lit, community life underpinned by secret deviance, Costasol embodies the paranoid fortress mentality of affluent enclaves in the neoliberal age, where the residents are barricaded inside their homes. It is depicted as a lifeless expatriate community, devoid of excitement, meaning, or any true engagement with the world. "The residents of the Costasol complex, like those of the retirement pueblos along the coast, had retreated to their shaded lounges, their bunkers with a view, needing only that part of the external world that was distilled from the sky by their satellite dishes" (Ballard 216). This estate functions as a sterile, artificial paradise where residents live in isolated comfort but suffer from existential ennui.

Residencia Costasol is not a community in any meaningful sense, as opposed to Estrella de Mar, where the inhabitant made a point to emphasize that they form a community. With the need to struggle removed, the potential for personal fulfillment is also eliminated. The residents of Costasol are little more than passive consumers of their own leisure, living isolated lives absent of any social bonds. Costasol thus represents the logical endpoint of post-capitalist leisure: a closed, affectless society in which all externality, all alterity, has been excluded. In contrast, Estrella de Mar survives – albeit precariously – by tolerating and even engineering pockets of chaos meant to stave off the entropy that has already engulfed Costasol. The Residentia Costasol, therefore, serves not only as a cautionary tale of the effects of excessive comfort but as a foil to Estrella de Mar, which might be languishing if not for the occasional bouts of violence. In this way, Ballard stages a dialectic between two forms of late capitalist decay: the sterile entropy of Costasol and the managed pathology of Estrella. Both are products of a system that has realized its utopian dream in its most banal and primal incarnation – freedom from labor, abundance of comfort – at the cost of memory, engagement, and affect.

Cinematic Mediation and Postmodern Hyperreality

In *Simulacra and Simulation*, Jean Baudrillard cites Disneyland as an example of a hyperreal utopia, masking the structures of control and consumerism beneath its carefully engineered spectacle. "Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest is real" (12). That is, Disneyland's overt theatricality; the contrived castles, anthropomorphic mice, and cheerful artifice operate as a decoy, creating a spectacle that displaces attention from the unreality of everyday life under late capitalism. Reality itself, under such conditions, becomes a simulation, a mediated construct masked by the reassuring fantasy of the imaginary. In this sense, Disneyland is not simply a place of escape from the real; it is the mechanism by which the fiction of reality is maintained. "The imaginary of Disneyland is neither true nor false, it is a deterrence machine set up in order to rejuvenate the fiction of the real in the opposite camp" (13). Umberto Eco in *Travels in Hyperreality*

echoes this interpretation, calling Disneyland a "perfect America" where the fake is even more convincing than the real. Disneyland's pristine streets and idealized historical pasts offer a purified, edited version of the American imaginary – one free of contradictions, conflicts, or contingency. In *Cocaine Nights*, J.G. Ballard responds to this logic not through parody, as many novelists have done before, but though inversion. Estrella de Mar functions as a dystopian mirror of Disneyland: both are carefully curated utopian environments, organized around control, homogeneity, and affective management. Yet, where Disneyland suppresses violence to maintain its illusion, Ballard's Estrella de Mar depends on violence to sustain itself. Genuine resistance is impossible because it is already accounted for within the system.

We have established that Estrella de Mar, like Disneyland, is not a real place in any culturally or historically grounded sense. It is overt theatricality and spectacle. But how is this achieved? One of the most important elements of Disneyfication is theming. In his study on Disneyization, Alan Bryman defines it as " . . . the application of a narrative to institutions or locations . . . . Theming provides a veneer of meaning and symbolism to the objects to which it is applied. It is meant to give them a meaning that transcends or at the very least is in addition to what they actually *are*" (15). Nowhere is this more apparent than on Main Street, U.S.A., a fictionalized small-town landscape that merges the nostalgia of quaint, small-town Americana with a sanitized, idealized vision of the past, thereby reinforcing utopian narratives about innocence, tradition, and national identity.

Estrella de Mar, like other Disneyfied spaces, is a themed environment, in this case a simulation of a Mediterranean paradise, with all the expected trappings associated with luxury, safety and elite retirement. This mode of artificial reproduction is, according to Fredric Jameson, central to the cultural logic of postmodernism. In *Archeologies of the Future*, he argues that Disneyfication "is the processes whereby inherited cultural images are now artificially reproduced, as in all those lovingly rebuilt city centers which are 'authentic' reproductions of their former selves" (215). This process, of course, renders any kind of locality improbable, reducing such Disneyfied spaces into marketable reifications of our fantasies. The architecture of Estrella de Mar is likewise designed to simulate an "authentic" cultural locality, but it does so by severing style from context, reducing history to decorative effect. It is not a Spanish town in any meaningful cultural sense; the architecture, aesthetics, and social forms are synthetic, homogenized, and imported. As Ballard makes clear, the town's surfaces are composed of aesthetic signifiers detached from context or history: The villas are designed in the style of "a new Arab architecture that owe[s] nothing to the Maghreb across the Strait of Gibraltar" but rather belongs "to the desert kingdoms of the Persian Gulf, reflected through the garish mirrors of Hollywood design studios" (Ballard 16)/"King Saud's larger-than-life replica of the White House" and "Aladdin's cave apartments" (Ballard 17), "mock-Andalucian streets" (Ballard 31), and edifices whose "Africanized aspect" appears derived from "a North Africa invented by someone who ha[s] never visited the Maghreb" (Ballard 34–35). The town is seen to also resemble "the halcyon country-town England of the mythical 1930s, brought back to life and moved south into the sun" (Ballard 66). This transplantation of mythic England into the Costa del Sol literalizes the artificiality of cultural memory in the postmodern condition. What results is a cultural pastiche of idiosyncratic incongruities, contributing to what Jameson called "the waning . . . of our lived possibility of experiencing history in some active way" (1991: 21). The community is, in essence, a hyperreal construct, a Disneyfied coastal utopia built to meet the consumer desires of affluent expatriates.

One of the more interesting aspects of Ballard's critique in *Cocaine Nights* lies in his exploration of how cinematic mediation has become constitutive of reality itself. This goes beyond the familiar postmodern concern with simulation to how film functions as both memory and perception within hyperreal environments. As Wilson observes, "Characters habitually confuse the real with the reel. Unlike Ballard's former usages of this trope, though, the reel, not the real, has become the dominant more of psychological existence" (155). This confusion is not merely metaphorical but represents a fundamental shift in how consciousness operates within commodified utopian spaces.

The residents of Estrella de Mar do not simply watch films and television; they inhabit a fundamentally cinematic mode of being. Bobby Crawford articulates this condition explicitly:

"There's a kind of amnesia at work here – an amnesia of self. People literally forget who they are. The camera lens needs to be their memory" (Ballard 262). Film, then, is not merely reflective but constitutive: "Film is the way we see our world." In this space, reality is not only observed but performed, recorded, and ultimately replaced by the cinematic lens. The residents do not inhabit a world of obvious artifice like Disneyland's cartoon castles; instead, they live within a reality that has been cinematically pre-structured, where the boundaries between authentic experience and mediated representation have dissolved entirely.

The park's immersive theming relies heavily on cinematic techniques – storyboarding, careful lighting, mise-en-scène, and narrative sequencing – to create immersive environments and shape visitors' perceptions and emotional responses. Universal Studios in Orlando, Florida, which is integrated into the larger entertainment complex, extends this logic by foregrounding film itself as both spectacle and environment. But Ballard takes this logic further, showing how entire communities can be organized according to cinematic principles.

The "theming" that Bryman identifies as central to Disneyization is essentially the application of film production techniques to architectural and social space. Just as a film set creates a convincing illusion through careful attention to visual detail while remaining fundamentally artificial, themed environments like Estrella de Mar produce authenticity effects through the accumulation of simulated cultural signifiers. The "mock-Andalucian streets" and "Aladdin's cave apartments" function as elaborate film sets, providing backdrops for lives that are performed rather than lived. The residents become both actors and audience in an ongoing film production that never acknowledges its own artificiality.

The consequences of such hyperreality extend beyond aesthetics. As Jameson famously argued in *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*, the postmodern world is characterized by a "waning of affect" and a collapse of historical consciousness. Under this regime, space displaces time as the dominant cultural logic: we no longer experience history as a meaningful continuum, but instead inhabit spatial simulations of the past – a condition he terms *a-historicity*. Whereas in modernism there is a sense of historical depth, postmodernism by contrast is marked by a collapse of historical consciousness in favor of simulated spaces that emphasis surface appearance as reference markers. Ballard's portrayal of the Costa del Sol is a textbook illustration of this phenomenon. The resort towns of *Cocaine Nights* exist in an eternal present, stripped of time, memory, and political struggle. The architecture of the coast is "dedicated to the abolition of time" (Ballard 34). Its residents live in an "eventless world" (Ballard 33), anesthetized by satellite TV and routine. In such a culture, there is no room for utopian impulse, no hope of improvement or change.

> Present time is provincial and empty. If humanity becomes too much taken with the present, we lose the possibility of imagining a radically other future. We lose the ability to hope. We lose what Bloch identifies as the *novum*: the unexpectedly new, that which pushes humanity out of the present toward the not yet realized future. (Moylan 21)

The idea of living in an everlasting present bereft of any hope for a different, more perfect, future appears to be one of the unintended consequences of a utopia achieved.

A-historicity breeds another postmodern symptom: depthlessness. With no visible markers of history, no monuments, no evidence of political struggle and change, and perhaps most importantly no memory of anything outside the resorts, the community is engulfed by a particular kind of existential blandness. This depthlessnes extends beyond a purely aesthetical understanding of culture, seen as unrooted in any historical meaning, to a moral depthlessness. The residents of Estrella de Mar are not only historically detached but emotionally disengaged. As the narrator observes, they are placid and numb; they treat violence not as a threat but as spectacle. Crime fails to elicit emotional responses, instead becoming yet another form of entertainment, another curated experience to punctuate the emptiness of leisure. Murders, arsons, and assaults are met not with horror but fascination.

This emotional detachment reveals how postmodern depthlessness operates as a mechanism of political neutralization. The flattening of affect corresponds to what Tom Moylan, drawing on Karl

Mannheim's distinction between the static aspect of ideology and the revolutionary aspect of utopia, identifies as a broader historical process: "utopia has been absorbed into the affirmative ideologies of the totalizing systems of Stalinist Russia, Nazi Germany, and the corporate United States. Each of these formations has contained and coopted utopia into the maintenance of the given system" (Moylan 8). Ballard's resort community represents the corporate iteration of this process, where utopian energy is channeled not into revolutionary transformation but into the maintenance of consumer satisfaction. The residents' inability to respond authentically to violence reflects their broader inability to imagine genuine alternatives to their current condition. In this context, Crawford's engineered transgressions function as a safety valve – providing the simulation of revolutionary disruption while ensuring that no actual challenge to the system emerges. The violence becomes consumable precisely because it poses no real threat to the structures that produce the community's underlying emptiness.

Conclusion: The Commodification of Dissent

In *Cocaine Nights*, Ballard reveals the collapse of the traditional boundary between utopia and dystopia under late capitalism, demonstrating how even violence and transgression can be absorbed as instruments of social regulation. Disneyland and Estrella de Mar represent two complementary strategies within what we might term the "curated transgression" apparatus of contemporary capitalism: the former suppresses conflict to preserve its illusion of harmony, while the latter engineers conflict to sustain social cohesion. Both environments function as hyperreal simulations where affect, agency, and historical memory are systematically managed, revealing how utopian desire no longer fuels political transformation but is redirected into aestheticized rebellion and commodified disorder.

The dialectical relationship between these spaces illuminates a broader transformation in the mechanisms of social control. Where earlier forms of capitalism relied on prohibition and external discipline, late capitalism has developed a system that maintains order not by suppressing desires but by anticipating and channeling them into predetermined outlets. Ballard's prescient vision of transgression-as-therapy has proven remarkably accurate in an era of branded activism, algorithmic radicalization, and performative resistance. From Che Guevara t-shirts to corporate Pride campaigns, from "punk" fashion lines to curated Instagram rebellions, the aesthetics of dissent have become fully integrated into consumer culture, serving to reinforce the status quo rather than challenge it. Both Disneyland and Estrella de Mar produce carefully calibrated emotional responses: wonder and nostalgia in the former, excitement, and transgressive pleasure in the latter. However, these affects remain contained within their respective spaces, unable to generate genuine political energy or historical consciousness. The result is what Ballard depicts as a society where rebellion becomes routine, transgression becomes therapeutic, and dissent is absorbed as lifestyle choice.

The spatial logic of these environments – their a-historicity, depthlessness, and hyperreality – extends far beyond theme parks and resort communities. Contemporary urban planning, from corporate campuses to gentrified neighborhoods, increasingly operates according to similar principles: the creation of controlled environments where potential sources of conflict are either excluded or carefully managed. The "smart city" initiatives, gated communities, and corporate "wellness" programs that characterize neoliberal urbanism all reflect variations on the Disneyland model, creating spaces where social control is exercised through environmental design rather than overt coercion.

In this sense, *Cocaine Nights* functions as both dystopian warning and inadvertent guide to resistance. By revealing the mechanisms through which transgression is converted into social stability, Ballard's novel points toward the necessity of developing forms of political action that cannot be reduced to spectacle, lifestyle choice, or therapeutic outlet. The most subtle accomplishment of late capitalism may be its capacity to transform resistance into a stabilizing force, yet this very ability exposes the system's reliance on the very energies it seeks to suppress.

Notes

1. This now famous quote is attributed both to Fredric Jameson, who in *The Seeds of Time* wrote "it seems to be easier for us today to imagine the thoroughgoing deterioration of the earth and of nature than the breakdown of late capitalism . . . " (xii), and to Slavoj Žižek, who later popularized the more punchy formulation "it is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism" in his lectures and writings. It is also the title of the first chapter (1) of Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism: Is There No Alternative*.
2. The notion of blueprint utopia is often used in Nathanial Coleman's work, see "The Problematic of Architecture and Utopia" and *Utopias and Architecture*, where it is described as a model conceived for total implementation.

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Notes on contributor

Marcin Tereszewski is an assistant professor at the University of Wrocław, Poland, where he specializes in modern British fiction and literary theory. He is the author of *The Aesthetics of Failure: Inexpressibility in Samuel Beckett's Fiction* (Cambridge Scholars Press, 2013) and co-editor of *Literary and Cultural Representations of Hinterlands* (Routledge, 2024): His current research interests include an examination of psychogeographical and architectural aspects of dystopian fiction, particularly in relation to J. G. Ballard's fiction.

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